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WHO IS THE GLORIA STEINEM OF INDIA?

For more than five decades, Indian women have built a feminist movement without a single figurehead — a sprawling collective that continues to reinvent itself, and whose very decentralisation may be its greatest strength

Urvashi Butalia

It has been a little over a week since Gloria Steinem, the iconic American feminist, died. The media has been full of stories about this extraordinary woman whose achievements were considerable, as were the controversies she was caught in.

Will the history of feminism give us another such hero? It's

hard to say. Steinem was an influential woman and her fame traversed many borders. She was also somebody who did not fear the limelight, although she did not necessarily actively seek it out. In the history of feminism, there aren't too many icons like her. Perhaps, this is why many are asking the question: is feminism no longer the force it was, has it had its day or has it morphed into something else?

But, feminism isn't the same

the world over. Nor is it that easy to kill. Once the battle against injustice and discrimination begins, the route it takes may not be straightforward or linear but it continues to be resilient. Further, in each location, in each context, feminist histories are localised and shaped by particular ground realities.

In many parts of the world then, feminism is alive and well. Take India, for example. Here, questions of land, labour, caste,

health, the environment and violence have long been central to women's activism. Indeed, one of the early slogans of the feminist movement defiantly claimed women's right to 'jal, jangal, zameen' (water, forest and earth).

Perhaps, then, the search for another Steinem is itself the wrong question. In India, feminist activism has often found its power not in a single figure, but in collective mobilisation around concrete struggles. Maharashtra offers a particularly revealing example.

Last December, women's groups all over the State came together under the collective banner of the Maharashtra Stree Mukti Parishad to mark 50 years of feminist activism in the State. Days of commemoration showed the richness and range of issues taken up by women activists. "Women came together from all over Maharashtra, rural, urban, everywhere. They looked at old and new issues. The conference was a wonderful example of how much work has happened in 50 years," says Nandita Gandhi, co-director of Akshara, an organisation born of the early days of the movement.

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A student protest at Gujarat University as part of the Navnirman Andolan, May 1973. (GETTY IMAGES)



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▲ The 18th-century monument complex of Bara Imambara in Lucknow. (GETTY IMAGES/ ISTOCK)

Harish Trivedi

Journalist and author Omais Ahmad's new novel, *Homecoming*, begins with the demolition in Lucknow of a small mausoleum of a forgotten *begum*, neither by a mob nor in a riot but by an High Court order.

As the first sentence of the novel puts it: "In the end it was a little thing." It certainly is in one way, for a previous novel by Ahmad, *The Storyteller's Tale* (2008), begins with the devastation of a whole city, Delhi, by Ahmad Shah Abdali. And another one, *Jimmy the Terrorist* (2010), features the great demolition of our times, that of the mosque in Ayodhya.

But this little thing has big consequences for the two

LOST IN LUCKNOW

A story about diminished aristocrats, doomed lovers and a changing city

lover-protagonists of *Homecoming*. He is named Hassan Reddy, grew up in Hyderabad, and has been practising as a dentist in Lucknow without showing any discernible interest in the city, or in its famed poetry and *tehzeeb* (refined culture), or in any of its residents. The first

patient he seems to take any notice of is an old gentleman called Ahmed Sahib, and that's because the latter hasn't got the money to pay him. Hassan now suggests that Ahmed Sahib could show him around the city, not because he is interested in it but rather to extract his pound of flesh.

On successive Saturdays, therefore, Ahmed Sahib turns up to show Hassan the best of this "city of poetry, of grace". He takes him first to a tailor where Hassan is measured up for a shirt (and not a *sherwani* as one might expect). Ahmed Sahib then wants to take him to a bookshop run by a local celebrity named Rambhai, except that Hassan flares up at the very name "Ram" and is with difficulty assuaged. All this may sound comical and ironical, but the flat and listless tone of the novelist betrays no such intent.

Faded grace

The final set piece is a *mushaira*, for which the duo travels to a *qasbah* (small town) called "Rudali" (in fact, Rudauli), as if there are no *mushairas* in Lucknow. A poet recites "low poetry, even doggerel," saying he



Homecoming
Omais Ahmad
Speaking Tiger
₹499

field trip for research in calligraphy. She speaks with NRI disdain about Indians who do not form queues, and when the tomb is demolished, she is furious. "There is nothing left for us here," she tells Hassan. "How can you stand it, Hassan?"

Meanwhile, Hassan has fallen for her at first sight at Delhi airport, admiring "the touch of foreignness, of the exotic" that she exudes, and also her physical "grace" that seems to trump for him the faded grace of Lucknow. "Even if the tomb had not been demolished, we were leaving" for England, he tells us quietly, thus puncturing Sam's moral indignation.

Hidden away

This is about all that happens in the novel in the present tense. But there's a lot more that is tucked away in backstories, which are summarily narrated, remain off-stage, and thus lose immediacy. There is Kothi Firaz and the diminished aristocrats it houses. There is even a *nawabzada* and a *tawaiif*, whose offspring migrate to England to escape the shame; Sam is their child.

Beneath the thin and brittle ice on which Hassan has been skating during his long sojourn in Lucknow, there is thus a deeper current of another Lucknow persisting in its old ways. But the two worlds are hardly connected, as if the novelist himself were a little lost between his diasporic plot and his deeply grounded sub-plot.

The writer taught English at Delhi University.

Swept away by time

Three women, across centuries, and their stories of courage and resilience

Ramya Kannan

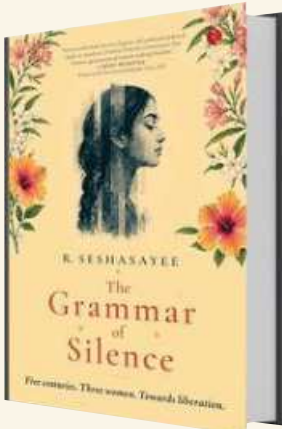
ramya.kannan@thehindu.co.in

Senior business leader R. Seshasayee's new novel, *The Grammar of Silence*, is an account of the lives of Tamil women navigating various systems within society. The women are trapped by these structures but find ways to overcome them through a characteristic, mindful defiance of convention – this is achieved silently, and without fanfare.

The book is a journey through different centuries, anchored by three women whose unique yet, in some ways, similar experiences illuminate the lives of women from different strata of society in the Thanjavur landscape.

There is Dharma, intelligent and accomplished in the arts but trapped by child marriage, abandonment and later, widowhood. She's an anomaly in her ritual-bound Brahmin household. Even her brother, an acclaimed scholar, knows she is smarter than him, but will never acknowledge the fact.

Fiction offers her the latitude to enter the world of Vinodhini, a courtesan living in the Thanjavur Maratha palace. Vinodhini inhabits a liminal space, at a moment when the traditional *devadasi*, once respected for



The Grammar of Silence
R. Seshasayee
Rupa Publications
₹395

her cultural accomplishments, is slipping into moralistic ignominy, forcing her to grapple with a changing social order.

The third strong female presence in this book, filled with characters of all hues, is Muthu, who becomes Mary Amelia. Born to a lower-caste woman, she negotiates structural barriers, with a dash of luck, to scale heights once unimaginable to her.

It is silence and a sense of sorority that binds together these women across the centuries, as also their lived experiences. Their triumphs, like those of other men and women of their era, have largely fallen by the wayside, swept away by time. Yet these heroines stand out, as though time itself has separated the wheat from the chaff.

Embedded in their accomplishments are aspirational stories and cues for women in similar circumstances, even in the modern era. The understated yet cleverly divergent paths they forge for themselves tell a tale of courage and resilience.

(Read the full review online.)

Author R. Seshasayee
(BUIJOY GHOSH)



▲ Women shoppers take a pause in Mysuru. (GETTY IMAGES)

jamaat, convenient interpretations of the Koran, the miraculous powers attributed to Auliya, Sharia traditions, the obligatory *mehr* reduced to a paltry sum, the misuse of triple *talaq*, and ultimately, the corrosive influence of money are all portrayed with non-judgmental honesty in these two stories.

Everyday localisation

Three cheers to the translators for marauding through English to match Indian rhythms. A mother calls out to her son: "Where are youuu?" The scrubbing of dishes is *pata pata*, the pouring of well water over one's head is *dala dala*, a person grumbles, *goni gona*. A pig falls into the pit – *daddakh*. Someone is thrashed with a cane – *chater*.

Local words are left untranslated: *marasinge* leaf, *namagorate* buds, *chaddi dost*, *ahirat*, *balpa*.

Quaint expressions too are retained in the original: "Nazir was talking as if he was deftly drawing out a strand of hair from butter"; "if a wolf falls into a pit, every man will throw a stone at it"; "you must see how big the bedsheet is before you stretch your legs".

"Why do you want to be a brahmin, Manji-gulaganji," asked Gundakka, fondly rhyming her name with those shiny red seeds children used as pawns while playing indoor games." One suspects the translator's extrapolation here to explain the rhyme.

The Konkani translator's note is comprehensive – it can be used as a blueprint for other books in this series. The sourcing of stories from magazines like *Jaag*, *Prajavani*, *Patirke* and *Kannada Prabha* makes a statement about the value of regional publications. It would have been useful to know how these five stories came to be selected.

Ultimately, it is refreshing to read stories that are unpretentious. The 'long-shorts' in this series establish that fiction is indeed subterranean social history.

The reviewer is a Sahitya Akademi translation award winner, and the editor of 250 Years Of Jane Austen: Indian Responses.

Pata pata, gona gona

The translators bend English to the rhythms of Indian languages in two recent anthologies

to snatch stale bread from someone's hand unless we have arranged to give them fresh bread," can be an eye-opener to youth resistance movements propelled more by idealism than a pragmatic Plan B.

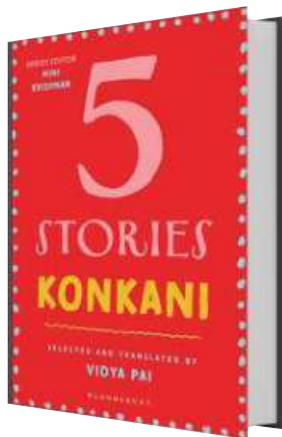
The most recent story in this collection is 'Man of the Forest' by Prakash Parienkar. Here, we have a neutral space bereft of particularity. This story could well have been written by Naga poet

Easterine Kire or any environmentalist with no variation in topography. This story signals the growing erasure of specific regional identities.

Kannada flavour

Baluvate Narayana in Vaidehi's 'Worlds Within Worlds' is a freeloader who sponges off everyone around him shamelessly, exploiting their hospitality while pretending to be a person of consequence. His wife Mankaliyamma's anguish is like that of Dorothea's who is tied up with Casaubon in George Eliot's *Middlemarch*. Such character sketches are rare to find in short stories.

Mogalli Ganesh's 'The Spinning Top' takes a very different route. What begins as a child's innocent fascination with a spinning top soon spirals into an intense portrayal of life in a Shudra community. Grief to the child is a lost top; to the animal trapped in the pit, it's a struggle for survival; and for the Dalit community, it is a struggle for dignity. The story's closing image – of a

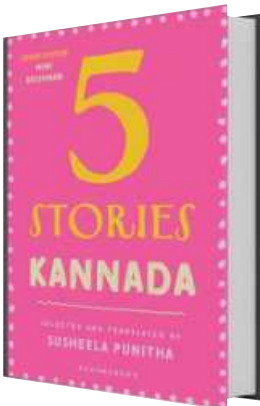


5 Stories: Konkani
Tris Vidyai Pai; ed. Mini Krishnan
Bloomsbury
₹499

child clinging to its mother and seeking refuge in the battered woman's body, "Take me back into your tummy, Avva," – will leave the reader restless for a long time.

The 1999 Kargil War and an India-Pakistan cricket World Cup final form the charged backdrop against which rumours spread of a Hindu girl eloping with a Muslim boy in Amaresh Nugadoni's 'This Heart Longs For More'. Much of the story's tension emerges from the seemingly ordinary setting of a tea stall, which becomes a gathering place for political debate and a window into how ordinary Hindus and Muslims respond to the anxieties of the moment. The result is a narrative that keeps one riveted.

Going one step further, Bolwar Kunhi ('Worship') and International Booker Prize winner Banu Mushtaq ('Not a Woman') take us into the heart of the Muslim experience. The role of the



5 Stories: Kannada
Tris Susheela Punitha; ed. Mini Krishnan
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Goan life

An honest, well-respected and simple couple prays for a child, and a son is born to them. The delighted parents indulge the child into adulthood. This son, however, dies in an aeroplane crash, on his way to Kuwait. How would the parents react, do you think? Read Damodar Mauzo's chilling story with a twist – 'Cry, Now'. It will stay with you. You are either that parent or you surely know of some such parents.

"The Ceremonial Bull" by Jayanti Naik and 'The Potter's Kiln' by Mahabaleshwar Sail exhibit the pain of a well-ordered interdependent community of simple-minded people, entrenched in their traditional structures of employment, caught in transition between forsaking their gods and filling their stomachs.

How can one protest against the powerful when the alternatives are all blocked? Pundalik Naik's 'Victory' plays out the problems of seeking justice through resistance. The lesson, "We have no right



When forwards become facts

Saadia Azim's book explores how misinformation travels from WhatsApp groups and social media into public life, fuelling vigilantism and violence

Ziya Us Salam
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WhatsApp is to social media what road rage is to the streets of India. Just as some people behind the wheel cannot stand another vehicle blocking their way on the street or in a parking lot and sometimes act on it, many people get so excited or enraged on receiving a message that they forward it to friends and colleagues without even reading it carefully. Often they are not sure of the source of the message, but they still forward it. Only some are careful to add ‘forwarded as received’ – meaning, they do not necessarily endorse the contents and they have not cross-checked the claims. Despite the disclaimer, however, the damage is often done.

A dangerous practice
As Saadia Azim, a public policy professional, writes in the well-crafted, painstakingly researched, and timely book, *Forwarded as Received*, “In India today, a WhatsApp forward is never just a message...Rumour turns into fact, outrage into truth and our sanity is chipped away by endless scrolling and forwarding... It is the storm of manipulation, suspicion and power that plays out in the palms of our hands.”

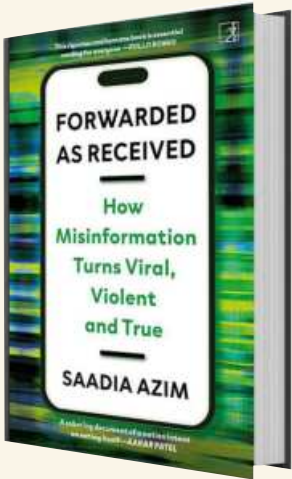
The book, replete with many such “rumours, lies, memes, half truths and digital absurdities”, is, as the author puts it, an “autopsy of misinformation, not its museum”. It exposes much of the disinformation on social media from 2014. Azmi casts her net far and wide, examining the role of fake photographs and videos and tracing the spread of messages ranging from the claim that the Indian Railways does not serve meat during the Hindu month of Sawan to the relentless peddling of hate, lies and half-truths on prime-time bulletins by news channels such as Sudarshan. She also recalls the huge outcry against Muslims as the alleged spreaders of the SARS-CoV-2 virus. During Operation Sindoor, when a section of the electronic media went to town with absurd messages such as ‘Karachi conquered’ or ‘Army chief flees Pakistan’, many people forwarded these ‘news’ items. Azmi writes, “During and after Operation Sindoor, confirmation bias became the engine behind some of the most viral falsehoods circulating across the nation’s digital and broadcast ecosystems.”

At times, such forwards can have dire personal consequences, particularly when misinformation feeds prejudice and vigilantism. We have seen how in the case of inter-religious marriages, for instance, social media and sections of electronic media often assume the role of family elders and oppose the union. Many couples have even been denied the joy of the union because of intimidation by right-wing activists. In one case that I know of, a couple, already married in the U.S., wanted to throw a reception for their families and friends. As their invitation card made it to WhatsApp, non-state actors jumped in, forcing them to cancel dinner.

The consequences can be even more devastating when misinformation turns into public accusations and targeted abuse. As Azmi writes, in the horrific case of Aftab Poonawala and Shradhha Walkar, in which Aftab allegedly killed his live-in partner, social media pronounced him guilty even before the police and courts had established the facts. Then there were women such as Hiba and Afreen, whose morphed photographs appeared on social media as part of the notorious Sulli Deals and Bulli Bai auctions. The women targeted in these campaigns were vocal critics of the government. Many Hindu men were later found to have been behind the reprehensible exercise. Long before the law caught up with the perpetrators, however, WhatsApp forwards had left some of the women afraid to leave their homes for weeks.

‘New commons’
The way forward is through fact-checkers and Azmi imagines a country where “truth travels by foot again”. During the Shaheen Bagh protests by women (2019-20), fact-checkers caught the many lies of pro-Citizenship (Amendment) Act activists.

Where sections of the electronic media failed, collaborative fact-checking and truth-building efforts worked, often with minimal budgets. As Azmi says, “In this flood, we stand ankle-deep in misinformation and chest-deep in consequence. The storm has shown us the danger of leaving truth to drift.... This is the hour for new commons to be reborn, not as nostalgic village squares but as a coordinated, independent network where citizens, platforms and institutions share responsibility for clarity.”



Forwarded as Received:
How Misinformation Turns
Viral, Violent and True
Saadia Azim
Simon and Schuster
₹599

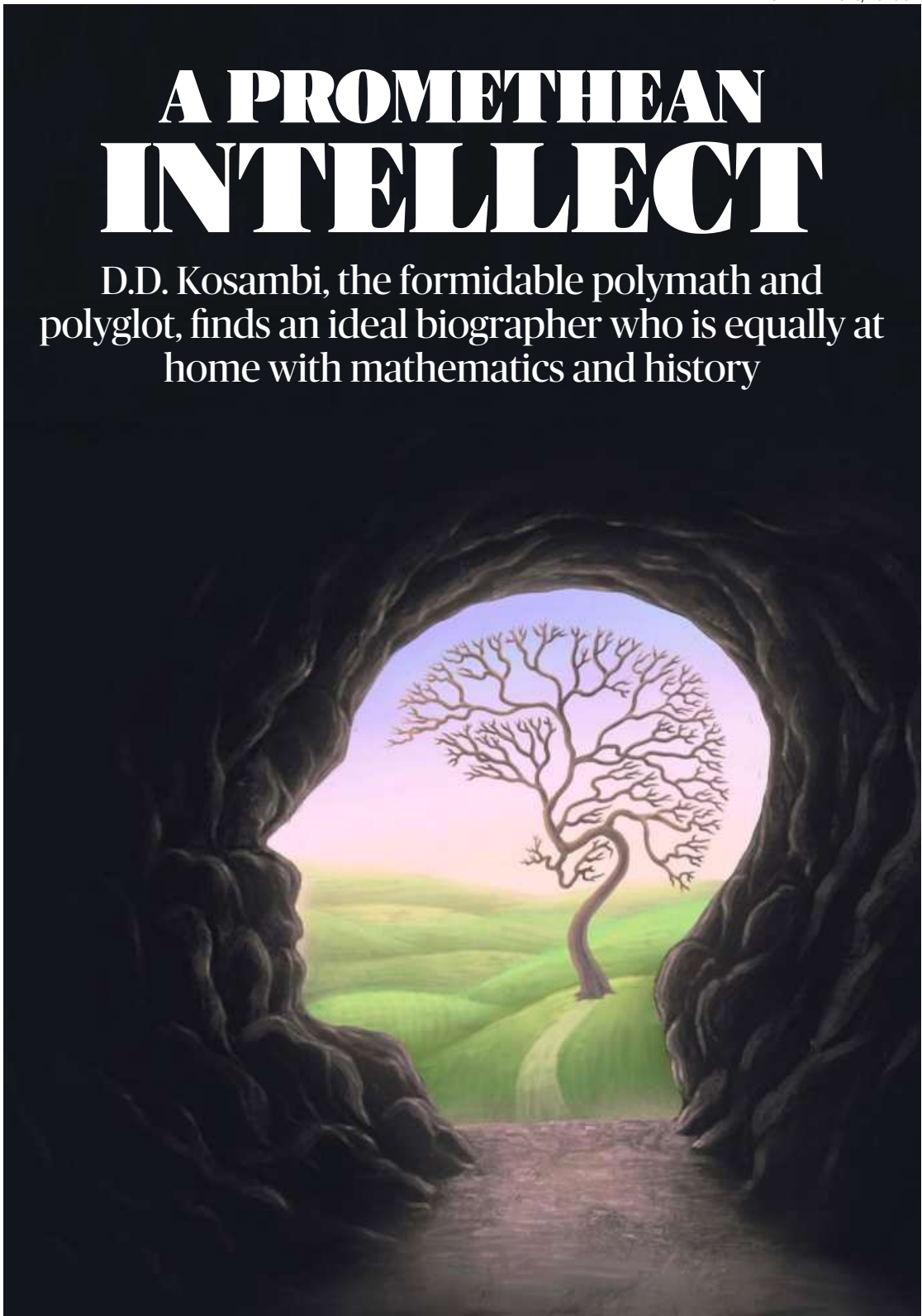
Ananya Vajpeyi

Ramaswamy, a scientist and educationist, had told me some years ago that he was working on a biography of D.D. Kosambi (1907-66). I was interested in DDK (as abbreviated by the biographer) for his superb 1941 essay on the classical Sanskrit poet Bhartrihari, composer of the *Trīṣataka* (*Three Hundred Verses on Eros, Ethics and Renunciation*), as well as for his father Dharmanand Kosambi, an outstanding scholar of Pali and an important proponent of Buddhism in modern Maharashtra. But it was not until Ramaswamy asked for my help with a quotation from Sanskrit that I became more invested in his project. His question led me to a gifted maverick named Jeffrey Moussaieff Masson, a lapsed Indologist, an excommunicated psychoanalyst, and a collaborator of DDK towards the end of the latter’s life. In the summer of 2024, I met Jeff Masson, now in his mid-80s, in Brussels, a small miracle facilitated by Ramaswamy.

This book itself is a concatenation of many miracles – its polymathic and polyglot protagonist, its author who writes equally well about mathematics and history, and a wealth of archival materials preserved in India and the U.S. at some of the best universities and libraries of both countries that Ramaswamy visited with amazing perseverance and thoroughness. Without exaggeration, the subject and his biographer could not be better matched. As Ramaswamy explains in his ‘Prolegomenon’, such painstaking research is necessary to do justice to Damodar Dharmanand Kosambi, “whose brilliance was, by all accounts, incandescent”.

Parallels with Ambedkar
Scientists, mathematicians, historians, archaeologists, Marxists, pacifists, and Sanskritists – each constituency knows a different DDK, and few can piece together the complex puzzle of this “myriad-minded man” (the title of another stellar biography, that of Rabindranath Tagore). Without attempting to re-tell a complicated story, I’d like to point out the unexpected similarities between, on the one hand, Dharmanand and D.D. Kosambi, and on the other, Dr. B.R. Ambedkar (1891-1956), who belonged to the generation between father and son. Ramaswamy explains at the very beginning that he must give considerable space in his book to Dharmanand’s life because he played an indispensable role “in the creation of the special genius” of DDK. Ambedkar’s precocious talents, too, were carefully nurtured by his father Ramji Maloji Sakpal.

Although the Kosambis were Gaud-Saraswat Brahmins from Goa, and Ambedkar was a Mahar Dalit from central India, their lives had many striking parallels. They



A PROMETHEAN INTELLECT

D.D. Kosambi, the formidable polymath and polyglot, finds an ideal biographer who is equally at home with mathematics and history

studied in America (at Harvard and Columbia, respectively), at a time when Indians were mostly sent to England for higher education. Dharmanand and Ambedkar both received scholarships from the Baroda Maharaja towards their studies abroad, which later turned out to be repayable loans. Both DDK and Ambedkar had diverse interests and a severe shortage of funds, thus feeling driven to cram an extraordinary amount of coursework into very tight periods of study.

They all spent lengthy sojourns away from their families, with deleterious, sometimes tragic, effects on their personal lives. Dharmanand and Ambedkar eventually became Buddhists. All three were widely respected for their scholarship, erudition, and politics. Both DDK and Ambedkar died relatively

young, their respective intellectual trajectories abruptly truncated. Dharmanand voluntarily chose death through the Jain monastic practice of *sallekhana* in 1947, two months before India’s independence.

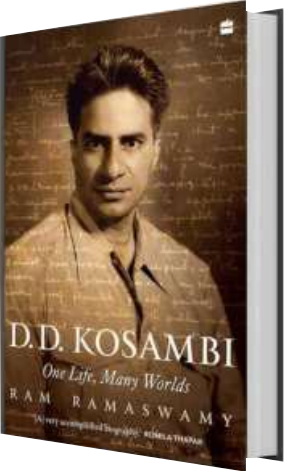
But the most surprising convergence between DDK and Ambedkar is also the least explored in the scholarship. It transpires that neither one was happily married, and both had long epistolary exchanges with educated white women. In both cases – of the Irishwoman Frances ‘Fanny’ Fitzgerald for Ambedkar and the Englishwoman Monica Felton for DDK – we do not find the man’s side of the correspondence. As we can discern from the letters written by their female friends, there was a disjunction between the traditional marital relationships that the two men had at home and the more equal intellectual partnerships they had outside. One could not be consummated and the other provided little by way of genuine companionship to these men who remained emotional loners and social misfits.

The battle with Bhabha
The most thrilling aspect of the biography is what DDK’s career reveals about the calibre and promise of Indian science in the years immediately before and after decolonisation. The deep ideological impress of Gandhi, Tagore, and Nehru on every aspect of nation-building is plain to see, with the profound

moral, political, and practical impact that this entailed for all fields of knowledge. While DDK’s adventures as an undergraduate at Harvard, and a young mathematics lecturer at Banaras Hindu University, Aligarh Muslim University, and Fergusson College Poona are riveting, the real meat of the book is the clash between him and the particle physicist Homi J. Bhabha – the father of India’s atomic energy programme – at the Tata Institute of Fundamental Research (TIFR) in Bombay, between 1945 and 1962.

Ramaswamy, who himself was a fellow at TIFR in the mid-1980s, was astounded by the near-complete erasure of DDK from the annals of the institution, whether for his founding status, scientific achievements, or administrative decisions. For all his brilliance, the mind-boggling range of DDK’s interests and the ever more pronounced eccentricities of his personality did not endear him to his peers. But in the end, we get a clue to the lasting light of D.D. Kosambi from the very line by Bhavabhūti that Ramaswamy had asked me about, quoted by Jeff Masson in his dedication of Bhāsa’s play, *Avimāraka*, to his deceased mentor and friend: “A man is not dead when those he loved remember him.”

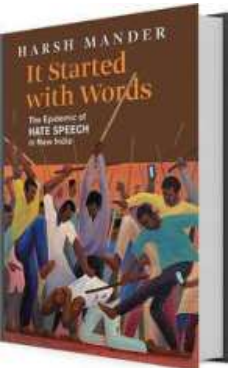
The reviewer is Professor at the Centre for the Study of Developing Societies, New Delhi.



D.D. Kosambi: One Life,
Many Worlds
Ram Ramaswamy
Fourth Estate
₹899

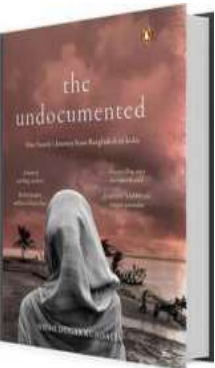
It Started with Words: The Epidemic of Hate Speech in New India

Harsh Mander
Speaking Tiger Books
₹499
Mander examines how hatred in India is produced and spread; who profits from it; and what happens when those who incite fear also command the machinery of the state.



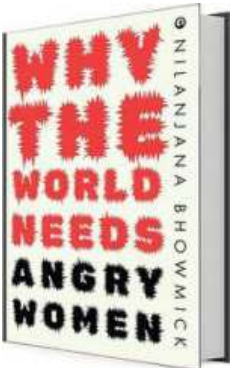
The Undocumented: One Family's Journey from Bangladesh to India

Nidhi Dugar Kundalia
Penguin Random House India
₹699
After 13 years of fieldwork, Kundalia writes the migrant as weather, hunger, motherhood, memory, shame, skill, anger, prayer and, above all, as a person who refuses to vanish.



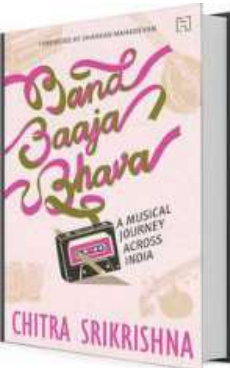
Why The World Needs Angry Women

Nilanjana Bhowmick
Aleph Book Company
₹699
A blistering manifesto in favour of the modern woman’s right to anger, Bhowmick shows how women’s anger is different from men’s anger. While men’s anger often rises out of the need to maintain the status quo, women’s anger challenges it.



Band, Baaja, Bhava: A Musical Journey Across India

Chitra Srikrishna
Hachette
₹599
Srikrishna, a Carnatic vocalist and educator, takes you on a journey across India’s musical landscape not as a history lesson, but as a way of understanding why this music has such a hold on you.



CONTINUED FROM PAGE 1

Three years earlier, in a major 65-day march called the Dignity March, survivors of sexual violence from across 24 States in India walked over 10,000 kilometres to draw attention to sexual violence. And during the many months of the farmers' protest outside Delhi, hundreds of women farmers came together to demand their rights. Multiply these instances many times over and you will still only have a snapshot of the Indian women's movement.

Among those who undertook the Dignity March were women from different villages in Madhya Pradesh. With the support of Maraa, a Bengaluru-based group, they were inspired to form a theatre group called Freeda. Today, they take the message of the importance of battling sexual violence across India through theatre. "This is our life now. Theatre allows us to give voice to issues we cannot talk about easily at home," says a member of the group.

The 70s momentum

The kind of activism is not something new. When Steinem first came to India in the 1950s, she spent some years travelling around the country. Among the Gandhian activists who were her travel companions, there must have been considerable numbers of women because in those years, and the ones that followed, women across India were centrally involved in many different movements.

For activists of my generation, the 70s were the turbulent and exciting years in which we came into our feminisms. The Supreme Court's shocking acquittal in 1979 of two policemen accused of raping a minor Adivasi girl called

Mathura acted as a catalyst for a countrywide movement against violence. Small and large collectives, and organised groups sprung up to deal with domestic violence, health, coercive contraception, caste discrimination, communalism, unfair laws; they brought out magazines such as *Baica* (Marathi), *Manasi* (Kannada), *Stree Sangharsh* (Hindi) and many more.

Our inspiration thus came not only from our mothers and grandmothers who were involved in the freedom movement but also from the thousands of women all over the country who were part of major movements, and were raising important questions.

The 60s and early 70s had already given us the Shahada movement, a grassroots Adivasi mobilisation against the exploitation and oppression of landless agricultural labourers in Dhulia district of Maharashtra. It brought large numbers of Adivasi and Dalit women into campaigns against exploitative landlords.

Among the key issues was the sexual exploitation women faced, and this was the focus of several discussions in the shivirs (gatherings) that were held.

The 70s also brought the anti-price rise movement, an all-woman agitation against hoarding and high prices that, at any given time, had as many as 25,000 women staging unique protests with signs, posters, and kitchen implements as part of their arsenal. Their protests were an inspiration for the Navnirman Andolan in neighbouring Gujarat.

In Bihar, Jayaprakash Narayan led a large group of students under the banner of the Chhatra Yuva Sangharsh Vahini in what came to be called the Bodhgaya movement. Chetna Gala Sinha, a student activist then, went on to

WHO IS THE GLORIA STEINEM OF INDIA?



make her life in Bihar and set up a bank, the Mann Deshi Mahila Sahakari Bank, for rural women. "I learnt so much from women (gatherings) that were held.

Recalling how their application to start a bank was rejected the first time because its founding members – poor rural women – were not literate, Sinha says they persuaded her not to lose heart. "We will learn to read and write and apply again," they said. And so they did, and they succeeded," says Sinha, who remains active with Mann Deshi Bank and was awarded the Nari Shakti Puraskar, India's highest civilian honour for women's empowerment, in 2018.

In the Bodhgaya movement too, women were central to the cause, and they questioned all

forms of patriarchy: why, they asked, in a protest designed to redistribute land taken from the Mahabodhi Temple management, were the land deeds allocated only in the names of men?

In northern India, the Chipko movement brought women out of their homes to protect their trees from being wantonly cut up and sold, a move designed to preserve the soil, water, and climate.

And in urban Maharashtra, the Dalit Panther movement, begun by Dalit (male) writers, eventually led to women writers pushing open the door and bringing to the forefront the question of caste discrimination. Authors like Urmila Pawar, Kumud Pawde, Kaushalya Baisantri, Malika Amar



Shaikh became household names, leading the way for others like Anita Bharti who turned into writer-activists. "For me, my writing became my weapon," says Bharti, a prominent figure in Hindi Dalit literature who helped establish Dalit feminism as a parallel stream within mainstream Indian feminism.

Speak out, speak aloud

It is against this context that we see the coming into activism of various women, individually and collectively, on what have become central issues in the feminist movement. In the early 70s, Fatima Burnad, a Dalit woman from Arakkonam in Tamil Nadu, was just out of college when she began work on social issues with a local group, Action for Political and Cultural Change. The only woman among a bunch of men, albeit of a reasonably progressive bent of mind, she was given to understand that because she was

a woman, the only work she could take up was tailoring. But she refused and fought to be allowed to work in areas she felt were important. "I managed to get them to let me use a Bobby scooter," says Burnad, now 73. The scooter gave her mobility and freedom, and she began work among agricultural labourers and women, encouraging them to farm government land, grow food, and beat poverty, as well as address problems of domestic violence, alcoholism among men, and so on. The organisation Burnad set up, Society for Rural Education and Development, today works with poor rural women.

Burnad was not alone in this: in a remarkable commitment to women, 23 organisations came together to build a community centre for rural women that still stands in Arakkonam and is widely used today. The media did not come rushing to Burnad to write about her work, but she continues regardless.

(Clockwise from left) A protester at New Delhi's Shaheen Bagh; Gloria Steinem (centre), who was inspired by the grassroots movements in India; and young students at the Jantar Mantar protests this July. (R.V. MORTHY, V. SREENIVASA MURTHY AND SHIV KUMAR PUSHKAR)



protests against the Citizenship (Amendment) Act in Delhi's Shaheen Bagh, it was young Muslim women who took centrestage. Two of them, Gulfisha Fatima and Safoora Zargar, both barely out of college, had to face imprisonment as a result.

In the battle to reclaim women's right to enter the Haji Ali shrine in Mumbai, it was again Muslim women who went to court and won. In the disability rights movement, it is younger women who are taking the lead. And in the recent protests led by the Cockroach Janta Party, youth cutting across caste, class and identity came together to demand accountability from the government.

Manorama and Burnad's trajectories are thus not atypical: across India, there are groups like theirs and women like them who have dedicated their lives, quietly, doggedly, without seeking publicity and recognition, to fighting for women. This is what marks the Indian women's movement as different from the West.

They have set up institutions that will remain long after they're gone, trained younger women to enter fields like journalism, published reports and papers to create knowledge, and worked for years with rural communities. But the remarkable, and distinguishing, feature of their work is that there is no one single woman who can be said to represent a whole movement. This remains true for the older feminists as much as it does for the younger ones who have taken on their mantle.

Perhaps, that is why the Indian women's movement will survive.

The writer is an activist and the founder of Zuban Books.

Shweta Shiware

Are you educated? Do you work? Do you wear what you want? Do you vote? Do you have a bank account? Thank feminism.

Gloria Steinem, the American journalist and social activist who died last week at 92, spent her life fighting for women to be taken seriously as citizens, workers, writers and sexual beings. She was also a woman with a strong sense of style: centre-parted, fuss-free hair, enormous aviators, bell-bottoms. The aviators weren't entirely a style choice. Coming from a family that suffered from hereditary myopia, she bought oversized men's Ray-Bans because women's frames were too small for her face. "People were always pinching me on the cheek and so I felt I had a very fat face," she told *Teen Vogue* in 2011. None of it stopped *The Washington Post's* Maxine Cheshire from dismissing her, in 1968, as "the miniskirted pinup girl of the intelligentsia". Decades of activism, and the aviators were still doing half the talking.

Which brings us to a contradiction: why must a feminist look the part? The impulse isn't uniquely Indian, but Arundhati Roy offers a counterexample. She has described herself as a "natural-born feminist", tracing it to a mother who, after divorce, taught her early "rule number one was look out for yourself". Yet, nothing about the way Roy presents herself is ascetic. Her curly bob and *kohl*-lined eyes are familiar, but so is her pleasure in clothes: raw-silk *kurtas*, flowing skirts, long dresses from Indian labels such as Péro and Eka. Her feminism never required her to be indifferent to how she looked.

But the suspicion persists. Kirti Sanon wore a bralette-style blouse for a Raksha Bandhan ad and was made to answer for it. The actor



CAN FEMINISTS HAVE SHAPED EYEBROWS?

Reflections on Gloria Steinem's passing and why women in India are still expected to look the part

asked when we would stop telling women what to wear, arguing that culture lives in the heart, not on the neckline. The campaign was withdrawn anyway. If culture can't be read from a neckline, perhaps feminism can't be read from an eyebrow either.

Fashion without an apology
Policing can be stranger still inside feminist spaces. I was once told that queer feminists should not wax their upper lip or eyebrows, or

hanker for Louboutins. I'll wear lipstick before I pop into the neighbourhood shop – it doesn't have to mean anything. You can talk about the politics of the sari or the exploitation of garment workers without anyone questioning your feminist credentials. Mention a hair Botox appointment or high heels, however, is not the same as rejecting femininity. An unshaved limb is no more authentic than a waxed one. Clothes can constrain us, certainly, but they can also be



and 70s, rejecting bras, high heels, handbags, hairspray, shaved legs and coiffed hair was a way of rejecting conventional femininity. There was good reason to be suspicious of an industry that made money from telling women how they should look. In *Fresh Lipstick: Redressing Fashion and Feminism*, Linda M. Scott argues that this suspicion could itself become another way of controlling women, turning a rejection of conventional femininity into a new standard for how a liberated woman should look.

Rejecting compulsory femininity, however, is not the same as rejecting femininity. An unshaved limb is no more authentic than a waxed one. Clothes can constrain us, certainly, but they can also be

The writer is a columnist and critic, with a keen focus on fashion, textiles, and culture.

GREEN HUMOUR

Rohan Chakravarty



Ruchira Gupta

Venice was full of light when the news came that Gloria had died. I was there for the 'Vital Voices Venice Dialogue', among women confronting authoritarianism across continents. Grief entered the room, but it did not leave me alone. Almost every woman there had known Gloria or been changed by an idea she set loose in the world. One remembered her wit, another, her attentiveness; another, the permission she gave her to trust her own experience.

As the stories moved around the room, sorrow became companionship. I thought: this is what Gloria would have wanted. We were not turning her into a monument. We were doing the work, listening to one another, seated in a circle.

A passage to India

Gloria came to India in her 20s, in 1956, drawn by the Theosophy of her mother and both grandmothers and inspired by Gandhi's non-violent struggle against British colonialism. She began her Chester Bowles scholarship at Miranda House in Delhi, but within two months left the security of college life to travel with Gandhian organisers responding to caste violence in villages in Ramnad, Tamil Nadu. She wrote in a later essay that her feminism was shaped by what she learned then.

There, she watched the Gandhians listen before trying to persuade and saw injured communities step back from seeking revenge. Gandhi's organising principles stayed with her. She taught me that change begins at the bottom and transforms the top; that if you want people to listen, you must first listen to them.

She carried those lessons into feminism and distilled their egalitarian spirit into a phrase of her own: "We are linked, not ranked."

India remained part of Gloria's inner map. Gandhi was at the centre of it, but so were women who widened his inheritance, like the freedom fighter Kamaladevi Chattopadhyay, whom Gloria

THE CIRCLE SHE KEPT

Remembering Gloria Steinem's friendship that was rooted in India, the influence of Gandhi, and a feminism built on collective courage



Torchbearers (Clockwise from far left) The late feminist icon Gloria Steinem; with Ruchira Gupta in Bihar's Forbesganj; and Gupta and Steinem. (GETTY IMAGES, LEENA KEJRIWAL AND MONA SINHA)

said was her last teacher. She saw Gandhi's ideas in operation at SEWA, led by lawyer-activist Ela Bhatt, who organised poor self-employed women into the largest trade union of unorganised workers in the world. They confirmed that history is made not only by the "great man" at the top, but by people discovering their collective strength.

Meeting Steinem That belief brought us together. A mutual friend told Gloria how I organised survivors of sex trafficking through my Forbesganj and Kolkata-based NGO Apne Aap Women Worldwide. Then she emailed me, in 2007, to ask whether I had time to take her through my work.

That year, I took her in an auto-rickshaw to Delhi's Subhash Camp migrant settlement where I worked, thinking I had little to show. It began to drizzle. We stood on the steps of a half-built *kucha* brick house as several women formed a circle around us and I translated. My first impression of Gloria was of a curious person who cared. But I was unsure how to

bridge the gulf between continents, race and language. Then Gloria spoke my truth. She'd left America to escape marriage to her fiancé and had an abortion in England on the way to India. She kept it secret for years, until she met women sharing their abortion stories. She said telling her secret set her free and taught her the power of collective courage.

TRIBUTE [1934-2026]

It changed how I organised. I learnt that sharing our truth as we experience it is better than long theoretical lectures. From Gloria I understood, for the first time, that the most radical thing you can do is be understood.

Words in arms Our bond grew because we were writers and activists. Neither of us believed words were separate from action. Gloria knew that language reveals power. She challenged the phrase "sex worker" and asked audiences to say

"prostituted woman". It turned a label into a question: who prostituted her, who bought her, and which inequalities made her available for sale? Words could conceal injustice or expose it.

In Kolkata, in 2012 and 2014, she walked with me through red-light areas and sat with women without hurry. In Bihar's Forbesganj, she listened to women and girls resisting caste destinies of prostitution. She carried their voices into her work. She stood beside Apne Aap, chaired our international advisory board, joined our Last Girl Awards and helped us insist that no woman or girl is for sale.

We travelled and wrote together, including a *New York Times* blog and the book *As If Women Matter* (2014). We argued, laughed and learnt. My Forbesganj, Kolkata and Delhi homes became her India home; hers became my New York home. My favourite image is Gloria opening her door and saying, "Welcome home." Friendship lived in shared meals, unfinished sentences, questions and editorial meetings.

We toyed with headlines for my memoir, *No More Cages, One Heart, Two Countries, Uprooting Hierarchy*..., and never agreed. I used to ask her about being accused of being a CIA agent, and she would smile and say that she had worked to take students to youth festivals as a student to earn some money. It was a job, and she did not regret it. But she added that she was always against American imperialism, believing that the world was a spaceship with everyone on it and borders were fictional, like migratory patterns. Her favourite books were Bruce Chatwin's *The Songlines* (1987) and Sven Lindqvist's *Exterminate All the Brutes* (1992).

We had long conversations about how feminism in the Global South differed from the West, and she would say, "We have a lot to learn from the original matrilineal cultures of the East." We discussed how the control of women's bodies was necessary to reproduce caste or race, and how the most fundamental of all hierarchies was patriarchy, which we learnt at

home. And when I asked her about Israel and Palestine, she said she didn't believe in states formed along religious lines.

A growing circle

On her last birthday, this March 25, Gloria wrote me a card: "I am glad our lives have overlapped. My birthday, not yours." It was a tender sentence, and so like her. She imagined life not as a solitary line, but as circles crossing other circles.

In an introduction to my forthcoming book of paintings, *My Forbesganj Garden*, she wrote that "the cycle of life is in nature". One we must protect. And told me: "Don't worry about what you can do, do what you can. Only time will tell if it's big or small. But do it as if it matters."

At our last meeting, this summer, we spoke about reincarnation and she said one life was enough for her. She looked frail but promised to live to 115 and see Donald Trump out of power. She used to call him nothing but a toupee. Her humour helped us survive politics without surrendering to it.

In Venice, women who knew her – actor Jane Fonda, environmentalist Susana Muhamad, fashion designer Diane von Furstenberg, technology executive Megan Smith and political strategist Huma Abedin – remembered that promise with an ache. Yet Gloria was present in our stories, in the conviction that listening is a form of organising and in our refusal of hierarchy. As I spoke, I felt that the circle did not remove grief. It held it.

Gloria's chair is empty, but the circle has grown larger. Our lives still overlap – in every woman who speaks, every woman who listens, and every last girl who tells a man, "You are not the boss of me."

She always said we have opened the doors for you, now walk through. I am not passing the torch but kindling your torch. And, all of us will hold our torch and keep them burning.

The writer is an activist-author, founder of anti-sex trafficking organisation Apne Aap and a New York University professor.



ALLEGEDLY

Licence Raj for laughs

Why not formalise India's joke-policing with exams, clearances and a 48-hour permit?

gangsters and sniffer dogs but none for stand-up comedians. Anyone who thinks he's 'got latent' can set up shop as a comedian. This *laissez-faire* approach has to stop. There's only one way to ensure it does: a licensing system for stand-up comedians.

Regulating comedy

I've already prepared a draft Bill. Once passed, it will be known as *Vidushakon ka Panjikaran, Anugyaapaan evam Vinayaman Adhinyam* 2026 (English translation: Registration, Licensing and Regulation of Clowns and Jokers Act, 2026). Under this law, any Indian who wants to perform stand-up comedy will first have to prove that he is a citizen of India. If he seriously believes he can do that, he should register himself with the Central Board of Comedy Certification (CBCC), which will be the nodal body for

regulating comedy shows. Wannabe comedians must submit online applications for a stand-up licence at the CBCC portal. Applicants found eligible will receive, by registered post, the hall ticket to appear for the Stand-Up Entrance Test (SUEET). The SUEET will be conducted twice a year by the globally reputed, highly credible exam-administering body, the National Testing Agency. Candidates who get 100/100 in SUEET will need to upload their mark sheets on the CBCC portal, along with a fresh application form and all the specified supporting documents.

The second round of applications will be scrutinised by the designated authority in the Ministry of Information and Broadcasting, after which it will go for approval to the Ministry of Home Affairs, the Commerce Ministry, the Ministry of Water

Resources, Ministry of Cooperation, and Ministry of Non-cooperation. Once cleared by all of these, the comedian will be invited to perform at the PMO. If the PMO gives clearance, he will be issued a Unique Stand-up Performance Identification number (USTUPID), which will make him eligible to perform anywhere in India (or abroad) without the hassle of seeking a fresh license or police permission in every state.

Show your ID card

But USTUPID-holders, before every performance, must deposit their passport and driving licence at the local police station. If they are performing abroad, they must deposit their passports and luggage at the nearest Indian embassy. And one more thing: they may receive compensation for comedy work only through an account opened for that purpose at the Nanganallur branch of the State Bank of India.

The USTUPID will be valid for 48 hours, after which the artist must log in to the CBCC portal and get it renewed for another 48 hours, and repeat this every 48 hours for the rest of his professional life. Non-renewal of USTUPID will result in its automatic cancellation, and if that happens, a comedian must wait for three years before being eligible to apply again. Any comedian without a valid USTUPID who is found giving a public or private performance, either offline or online, or found laughing to himself at a joke he cracked in his own mind, will be prosecuted under the UAPA, PMLA and YOLO. If the above regulatory provisions are implemented in toto, I have no doubt even Gen Z will drop the idea of stand-up comedy as a career option. But the million-dollar question is this: Does India have the political will to pass this law?

G. Sampath, the author of this satire, is Social Affairs Editor, The Hindu.

TRICKTIONARY EPISODE 37

DON'T HATE ON NRIs

Do you think we are all sitting in AC rooms and judging India?

Dear readers, first of all let me apologise for my recent silence. If my calculations are correct, we have not had one of our conversations for about a month or so. For unavoidable technical reasons, I was not able to send my column on time last month. And for this, I am truly sorry.

Rest assured that, in the future, this writer will make every effort to avoid such intransigence.

The inspiration for this fortnight's dispatch comes from my trip to Bengaluru last month. I was invited to an evening of food and beverages by a group of local friends. As the evening progressed, and as beverages were consumed

with gay abandon, we began to discuss, as all men of a certain age do, the future of India.

Overall, we agreed that the future of India is bright. And even if there are temporary challenges, the creativity and energy of our youths will save us. Everyone agreed and we had another beverage.

And then this one fellow leaned over and said: "I think the future of Kerala is doomed. Also, Tamil Nadu is finished. And don't even get me started about Andhra Pradesh. Totally hopeless."

Excuse me, I replied, but you just agreed that the future of India is very bright. And now you are



Woman Holding a Fan (1895) by Raja Ravi Varma. (WIKIMEDIA COMMONS)

State-riotism

telling me that every single State in India is doomed except your personal State? He immediately told me to shut up and not make any comments because it is easy for NRIs to sit in AC rooms and pass comments about India.

Friends, first of all, most of us NRIs in the U.K. have no air conditioning whatsoever. In fact, the

State-riotism

/stet'raiatizm/ noun

Definition: The paradoxical belief that India is the greatest country in the world exclusively because of one's own State, district, or household, while simultaneously maintaining that every other State in the nation is useless, hopeless, and an active drag on national progress.

Related forms:

State-riotist (*noun*): A person who practises state-riotism

State-riotic (*adjective*): Displaying characteristics of state-riotism

State-riotically (*adverb*): In the manner of a state-riotist

situation here is absolutely horrible. Right now, at this very moment, I am surrounded by at least half a dozen potted plants that are clinging to life by the finest thread. Sweat is pouring down my face like one of those fountains outside an Indian airport that is like a huge coffin gently overflowing with water. In fact, it is so hot that my computer is barely functioning. I have two pedestal fans and both of them are pointed directly at my face. The impact is one big fat zero. I am dying.

Secondly, my meeting in Bengaluru reminds me of one of the more interesting things about Indian patriotism. Not everyone's patriotism, of course. But some people's conception of Indian patriotism.

These people are very funny. If you ask them which is the best country in the world, they will immediately say India. But if you

ask them which is the best State in India, they will say that their State is the best, and that every other State is absolutely useless and totally hopeless.

It does not end here. If you ask these people about their State, then things get even more interesting. They will say that their district is the best, and all other districts are useless, hopeless, lawless or godless.

And we can go on and on. They will go from district to *taluk* to block to *panchayat* to *gram* to their own house.

Essentially, they are saying that India is the greatest country in the world because of their house, district or State.

Friends, do you see the peculiar problem with this? Do you see why we need a new word for this paradox? And that word is: state-riotism.

Example sentence: "Venkat's state-riotism was in full flow at the dinner party. Within 10 minutes he had declared India the future superpower of the world, Karnataka the engine of that superpower, Bengaluru the engine of Karnataka, and every other State a collection of freeloaders who should be grateful that his tax money was keeping the country alive."

Have you recently met any state-riots? How do you resist the temptation to hit them with a plate or a spoon or a badminton racket or something?



Sidin Vadukut helps early stage companies communicate better. He blogs at www.whatay.com.

GOREN BRIDGE

Bob Jones

Can of corn

North-South vulnerable.
North deals

South won the opening spade lead with his ace and he regretted his timid bidding. 13 tricks seemed like a "can of corn", needing only a 3-2 diamond split or for the jack of hearts to fall in one, two, or three rounds. He expected that quite a few of the other pairs in the game would bid a grand slam on this deal and that he was

doomed to get a poor score. He cashed the ace of hearts, followed by a diamond to the ace. He discarded a spade and a club on the king and queen of hearts. When the jack did not fall, he led a diamond to his king. When the suit failed to split 3-2, he could no longer make his contract

Assuming that South was correct in thinking that he would get a poor score if 13 tricks were

available, he should have played as if 13 tricks were not available. After cashing the ace of hearts, he should have played a low diamond from both hands! East would win and return a spade to South's king. Now South can lead a diamond to dummy's ace and take his two discards. A club to his ace would be followed by a claim, knowing that all his remaining diamonds were good.

NORTH
♠ 7 5 2
♥ K Q 10 9 6 2
♦ A 6
♣ 9 5

WEST
♠ J 10 9 6
♥ 8 4
♦ 8
♣ Q 10 7 6 4 3

EAST
♠ Q 8 3
♥ J 7 5 3
♦ J 10 5 3
♣ J 2

SOUTH
♠ A K 4
♥ A
♦ K Q 9 7 4 2
♣ A K 8

The bidding:
NORTH 2♥
3♦
*Maximum with a high card in diamonds

EAST Pass
Pass

SOUTH 2NT
6NT

WEST Pass
All pass

Opening lead: Jack of ♠

QUIZ

Easy like Sunday morning

The 500th edition: a refresher from past quizzes

Berty Ashley

1 Cheshire cheese was reportedly once sold in moulds shaped like a grinning cat. According to one traditional explanation for the expression "grinning like a Cheshire cat", the cheese was cut from the tail end, leaving the grinning head as the final piece. Which 1865 work of children's fiction immortalised this character?

2 Harald "Blåtand" Gormsson was a 10th century Danish king associated with the unification of Denmark and parts of Norway. His nickname referred to a discoloured, presumably dead, tooth. In 1996, engineers from Intel, Ericsson and Nokia were working on a short-range wireless technology to share data, and gave it a temporary codename, named after him. What is the literal English translation of 'Blåtand'?

3 These two characters have been rivals since their 1949 Warner Bros. cartoon debut *Fast and Furry-ous*. With one trying to entrap the other with the help of Acme Corporation equipment. Their adventures are famous for their deliberately impossible "cartoon physics". Scientifically, the pair are *Geococcyx californianus* vs. *Canis latrans*. How is this pair better known?

4 An influential 18th century French military commander is popularly associated with the spread of right-hand traffic across much of continental Europe. Britain, which was not conquered



This country's unique flag, depicting the sun and moon, is shaped to represent the mountainous terrain it is renowned for. (GETTY IMAGES)

by him, retained its tradition of driving on the left, and spread it across its Asian colonies. Who was this commander who is often linked to the enduring difference in road traffic conventions?

5 To close incisions and certain wounds, ancient Indian surgeons put a certain insect on the job. It would bite the edges of the wound with their powerful mandibles. The surgeons then severed the insects' bodies, leaving the jaws gripping the tissue and acting like tiny surgical clips. What were these early biological 'staples'?

6 The name of this string instrument refers to its being a smaller version of another

instrument whose shape resembles an almond. It has eight strings arranged in pairs and was popularised in Indian classical music by Uppalapu Srinivas. Which instrument can be seen being played by Shashi Kapoor in the song 'Tum Bin Jaoon Kahan' (Pyaar ka Mausam, 1969)?

7 *Kryptopterus vitreolus* is a small freshwater catfish native to Thailand and popular in the aquarium trade. Its body is remarkably translucent, allowing much of the light to pass through it. This feature renders the catfish its name. By what common name do we know it?

8 Dinosaurs are often popularly divided into herbivores and

carnivores, but palaeontologists classify them according to the structure of their hips into saurischians and ornithischians. The names come from Greek roots: 'schian' means hip and 'sauri' and 'ornithi' refers to two types of present-day animals, one that looks like a dinosaur and the other that behaves like them. Which two modern-day animals give these groups their names?

9 *Do Geese See God?* is a 2004 short film directed by David Slade, starring Blair Underwood. The film follows a man obsessed with finding inner salvation and uses circular, repetitive elements in its narrative. The title itself is a particularly appropriate clue. What is special about it?

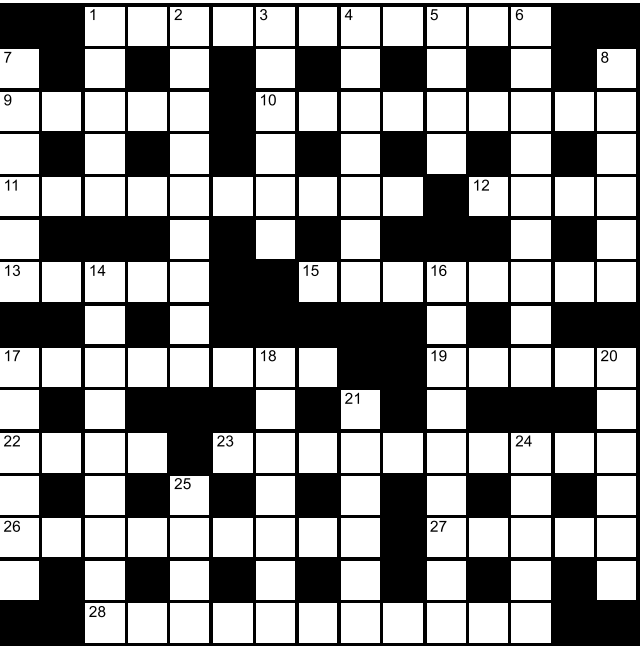
10 This country's national flag consists of two joined triangular pennants and is the world's only national flag that is not rectangular. It has a crimson field, a blue border, and a white crescent moon and sun. Which is this country whose unique flag is apparently shaped to represent its mountainous terrain?

A molecular biologist from Madurai, our quizmaster enjoys trivia and music, and is working on a rock ballad called 'Coffee is a Drink, Kaapi is an Emotion'. @bertyashley

1. Alice's Adventures in Wonderland
2. Bluetooth
3. The Road Runner and Wile E. Coyote
4. Napoleon
5. Ants
6. Mandolin
7. Glass catfishes
8. Lizards and birds
9. Pallidrome
10. Nepal

Answers

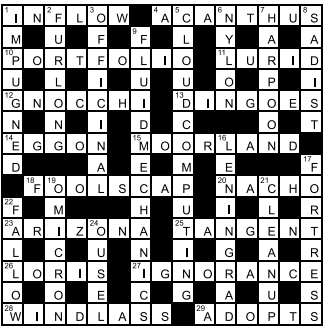
THE HINDU SUNDAY CROSSWORD NO. 73 (Set by Incognito)



- Across**
- 1 Reducing trimming of feathers (7,4)
9 Extra-terrestrial and Neil Armstrong initially returned (5)
10 Safe after Truman releases an elephant (9)
11 Plot criminal's crime (10)
12 I'm leaving Tim with old female at youth centre to get food (4)
13 Claw found in hospital once (5)
15 Woo with song and dance, perhaps, Ms. Williams, accompanied by musical notes (8)
17 Organisation of brat and punk becomes insolvent (8)
19 Violently step on small cockroaches, for example (5)
22 Destructive flier from Cambridge destroyed in absence of Edgar (4)
23 Sam returned with criminal carrying recipe for cheese (10)
26 What Adam was to Eve? One of the ship's crew! (5,4)
27 Insertion from Indiana group (5)
28 Some savage tribals may be recruiters (4-7)
- Down**
- 1 Before noon, vehicle goes around one pile of stones (5)
2 Pet in Reno produces device to cut into can (3,6)
3 Trainee flier follows Indian Navy (6)
4 University in Indian State with revolutionary water colour painting (7)

- 5 Loves Pastor's expression of dismay (4)
6 Loans ain't arranged for citizens (9)
7 Lucky emblem from master with highlander (6)
8 Greek river bird (6)
14 Boy held ring manufactured for famous flier (9)
16 Skill displayed by old Peter is extraordinary (9)
17 What the lawyer was hoping to get in the clothing department? (6)
18 A harp designed with love by husband for ruler (7)
20 Yes... In Spain, seat is modified for afternoon nap (6)
21 Show and hide? (6)
24 I leave oasis and import model kilns (5)
25 Mountain insect returned after end of June (4)

SOLUTION NO. 72



Taking on the
slithery kind with
a rare audacity



Shirley Philip
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The first king cobra I ever saw was neither in a zoo nor on a television screen. It was in the courtyard of my grandfather's brother's house, its magnificent hood fully spread, swaying gently, as though it were the undisputed monarch of the land. To my young mind, it was the very embodiment of death.

I stood transfixed. My grandfather walked towards it with measured, unhurried steps. There was no trace of fear in his demeanour, no hint of hesitation. In his hand was only the weathered wooden staff that rarely left his side. Then to my utter astonishment, he spoke to the cobra.

Whether he believed the snake understood him or whether it was simply his way of confronting danger, I shall never know. But the quiet firmness in his voice still echoes in my ears. The response was a long, angry hiss, the hood flaring wider in contempt. Grandpa admonished the snake almost as if he was reasoning with a little child.

When I was expecting the cobra to fly at him and strike, his staff descended in one swift, perfectly judged move. The cobra crumpled to the ground and silence settled over the courtyard.

This summer, Kerala's newspapers were full of reports of snakes entering homes and tragic deaths from snakebites. Some time ago, I watched an episode of a programme of Goa's snakes. The snake catcher equipped with a snake hook, calmly caught venomous snakes before releasing them into their natural habitat. Watching him, my thoughts travelled instantly back to that afternoon in my grandfather's courtyard.

He and my grandfather belonged to different worlds. His mission was both protection and conservation; my grandfather's was protection. He carried a snake hook; my grandfather a simple wooden staff. Their methods reflected the times in which they lived. In an era when trained rescuers did not exist, my grandfather responded to desperate calls from frightened villagers, protecting families from an immediate threat. Today, knowledge and conservation rightly guide our response to these remarkable creatures. As the credits rolled, I found myself thinking not about the snakes but of the two men who faced them. Their worlds were different, their methods were different, but each met danger with stoic calm. That thought lingered after the television was switched off.

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Every generation has its own story. My parents' generation grew up with very little and spent much of their lives building. My generation was somewhere in between. We were expected to work hard, create something of our own, and leave some behind for the next generation.

I recently came across the term "bed rotting". For those who haven't heard of it, it is essentially spending long periods in bed doing little. Not sleeping. Not necessarily recovering. Just lying there, scrolling, watching something or opting out of the world for a while.

This is Gen Z's way of dealing with stress and exhaustion. Fair enough. Everyone needs to switch off. Life can be exhausting, and there is nothing wrong with taking a break. But it got me thinking about something much bigger than bed rotting. Are we slowly raising a generation that is becoming a little too comfortable with comfort?

Interestingly, on the one hand, I see young people out on the streets demanding accountability. They question institutions. They challenge authority. They speak openly about things earlier generations suffered through silently. That is what a healthy society needs. But then I see instances where the very same "Gen Z" identity is almost used as an excuse for not having to deal with inconvenience or responsibility.

Remember the young woman whose video went viral after she got into an argument with Army personnel over traffic restrictions in a highly sensitive area? One of the arguments she used was, I am Gen Z and I am uncomfortable with the regulation. I could not help wondering when did being Gen Z become a new category of exemption? Sounds ridiculous. Of course, one individual does not represent an entire generation. They should be able to question everything, but they should not necessarily be questioned themselves. That is where the conversation gets uncomfortable.

An ecosystem for doing nothing
My generation also had its share of doing nothing. We listened to radio, we hung around with friends, and wasted afternoons. But we didn't have an entire digital ecosystem designed to keep us there.

Today, one reel leads to another. Food comes to the door. Shopping comes to the phone. GPS tells us where to go. Algorithms increasingly tell us what to watch, what to buy, and even what to think. Convenience is wonderful. But let's ask while we are removing so much friction from life, are we also removing some of the experiences that build resilience. We do not develop resilience by being comfortable. We develop it by dealing with things that are not.

We parents are partly responsible. Many of us have told our children, "I didn't have what you had. I want you to have everything." We meant it with love. We gave them better education, travelled with them, bought them things we couldn't afford and paid for experiences.

But somewhere along the way, we confused giving them opportunities with removing every obstacle. A child who is allowed to fail learns something. A child who is rescued every time could learn something else. Experiences are great. But what



The comfort curse
Gen Z comprises remarkably driven youngsters
but also those with a sense of entitlement

do they lead to?

I hear the phrase "invest in experiences" often these days. Yes, by all means. Travel, explore, meet people, see the world, and experience different cultures. However, an experience should leave something behind, a perspective, a skill, a memory, an idea or a little more maturity.

I have seen young people whose parents funded sabbaticals, travel and every possible experience, only for them to struggle when financial independence arrived. I have also seen the opposite, young people given family money as seed capital, who took the risk, failed, tried again and then built something of their own. Same privilege. Very different outcome. For one, parental support was a safety net. For the other, it was a launchpad.

The flip side

Then there is AI. I am a big believer in technology and AI. But every convenience comes with a small danger too.

If we stop doing something because a machine can do it for us, we will also stop developing the ability to do it ourselves. We stopped remembering phone numbers as our phones remember them. We stopped navigating as GPS does it for us.

The question is not whether we should use AI. Of course, we should. The question is whether we become so dependent on it that we stop exercising our own curiosity and judgment. The greatest danger is not that AI becomes smarter than us. It is that we become comfortable being less smart because AI is available.

What will Gen Z do with what it has been given? I don't think Gen Z is lazy. There are remarkably driven young



The greatest danger is not that AI becomes smarter than us. It is that we become comfortable being less smart because AI is available

people out there starting businesses, building careers, creating art, and doing things many of us couldn't have imagined at their age. But another section seems to have inherited a great amount of comfort without necessarily inheriting the urgency earlier generations had to develop.

Losing hunger

That is the part that worries me. Not because they are Gen Z. But because too much comfort can quietly take away the hunger that makes us build.

We parents need to accept some responsibility for that. We wanted our children to have everything we didn't have. What we should also have given them was a little more of what we did have, the need to earn, the ability to wait, the freedom to fail, the responsibility to stand on their own feet and the satisfaction of knowing "I did this myself." You cannot demand accountability from everyone else and ask for an exemption when it is your turn to be accountable. You cannot demand freedom without accepting responsibility. You cannot question authority without also questioning yourself. And you cannot spend your life avoiding discomfort and expect resilience to magically appear when life gets difficult.

That is the real lesson behind bed rotting. It is about what happens when comfort becomes a lifestyle rather than a pause. Every generation needs to ask itself what it is doing with what it has inherited. Our parents gave us something or nothing. We built on it ground up. Now we have handed something much bigger to our children. The question is whether they will use that comfort to build more, contribute more and become more, or simply consume more.

Generations are not remembered for what they were given. They are remembered for what they did with it. That to mind is the uncomfortable question Gen Z, and those of us who raised them, should be asking, when comfort is no longer the problem, what will give us the reason to get out of bed?

FEEDBACK

Letters to the *Magazine* can be e-mailed separately to mag.letters@thehindu.co.in by Tuesday 3 p.m.

Cover story

Whatever the arguments for and against the technicalities of publishing, ultimately readers can only see censorship and breach in freedom of expression at large come into play. (The book stops here'; Sept. 6) Circumstantially, one infers that the present despotic ruling dispensation intervenes, by all possible means, to suppress voices of dissent.

Chelat Gopalakrishnan

There is something unusual in the publisher going back on their word and refusing to publish a book, possibly due to direct or indirect pressure. This is a direct attack on freedom of speech and expression, a right guaranteed under the Constitution, and so, the refusal to publish cannot be considered fair or in order.

V. Padmanabhan

Access to all

The history of temple-entry reform shows that legal equality requires sustained vigilance. (Opening the temple door'; Sept. 6) Laws alone cannot remove entrenched exclusion. Temple administrations should publish clear access rules, establish grievance mechanisms and ensure that discriminatory customs are not allowed to be revived. Constitutional morality must guide public institutions, including places of worship.

Abbharna Barathi

Legendary stories

Biographies of legends make for compelling reading, irrespective of the field, because they

open up the possibilities of human greatness and, in doing so, offer inspiration. (A genius in spate'; Sept. 6) Some, however, go beyond the mere recording of facts and preserve a wealth of material that acquires value in other contexts. Duncan Hamilton's discursive exploration of Garry Sobers, enriched by first-hand experiences, is what makes the book stand apart.

S. Sundareswara Pandiyan

Mirroring society

Patriarchy is deep-rooted and well-entrenched in many parts of our society. (Madam Sir'; Sept. 6) As such, even progressive filmmakers can be constrained by commercial considerations, audience expectations and prevailing social attitudes. Such films reflect the reality of our lives, where male ego is pervasive and inescapable for women. To build a more equitable and progressive society, filmmakers need to break out of this mould and follow the path shown by Sandhya Suri in her film, *Santosh*.

Kosaraju Chandramouli

Beyond the museum

The collaboration between designer Sabyasachi Mukherjee and the Met shows how museum objects can inspire contemporary design without imitation. (Jewels of the tomb'; Sept. 6) Yet, the collection raises a question: can such historical storytelling reach ordinary Indians? Museums should create affordable replicas, public exhibitions and digital archives, allowing craftsmanship and heritage to remain accessible beyond the luxury consumer.

A.S. Nithish Kumar



MORE ON THE WEB
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The language that works

Impactful words may not always need the backing of a high-decibel broadcast

Amal Paul

Changing moods of the monsoon

The rains once arrived steadily and lingered, unlike the short cloudbursts now

Hari Arayammakul

Empathy is the beginning of humanity

Raise children with the essential life skill of respecting the feelings of fellow beings

M. Hajura Parveen

The power of words

They transform mindset, instil confidence, and kill self-doubt

Agna Prem

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A job title or position, symbolised by a chair, has many utilities. Besides providing regular engagement and financial security, it offers positional power. This power lends a chair a magnetic appeal. Handled and channelled well, the positional power enables us to not only influence desired behaviour but also drive and make an impactful change, be it in office, institution, or society.

Yet, for many of us, our relationship with the chair is one of obsessive attachment, which later turns out to be problematic and a pain.

A title, through its own inbuilt spell, exposes many of our vulnerabilities. First, overwhelmed with positional power, we fail to remain grounded. We are blind to the fact that people gravitate towards us largely due to the position we hold. Bereft of this realisation, we create our

When life strips
away titles

**What will remain are personal
qualities: character, skills, attitudes**



own make-believe empire of supremacy. Secondly, trappings of power put our value systems to test. We risk our sense of purpose being derailed and integrity compromised. Thirdly, we start believing the sycophants around us as our real friends. Self-absorbed in this illusion,

we get detached from people who should really matter to us, and remain deprived of their honest feedback. Another serious pitfall, born out of self-importance, is that we don't feel the need to learn new skills and upgrade ourselves.

Power derived from chair

exists till the source, that is the chair, is with us. Without chair, what remains is our personal qualities – character, skills, attitudes – all part of personal power. A life without chair can very well be led gracefully and enjoyed cheerfully provided we savour our sense of wonder, continue invested in learning, and pursue our interests and passions.

Yet, we dread a scenario without chair. Retirement from office, for instance, turns out to be traumatic for many of us. More the trappings, more the trepidation and trauma. Even without any problems relating to money, still, separated from chair, many of us sulk. Devoid of perks, salutations, adulations, flatterers, sycophants, a life without title appears hollow, lonely, and miserable.

One major factor behind the misery is that we tie our sense of self-worth to our job title, which becomes a mask for who we really are. The world rewards that mask with validation, approval, and

applause. Clearly, when our self-worth becomes dependent on the titles, our sense of self becomes fragile. If who we are depends on what position we hold, then any loss of that – because of burnout, layoffs, retirement or illness – can feel threatening.

Ignorantly assuming the worldly position, status, and authority as permanent, we often behave arrogantly or irresponsibly. That life can strip away or dismantle the transient constructs of credentials, labels or titles, therefore, could be a powerful self-awareness that should strike us early, when we are in the midst of enjoying positional power, clinging tightly the labels. It helps immensely to appreciate that underneath the job titles, there is a human being who needs to be developed with virtues like curiosity, learning, empathy, compassion. That enlightened self doesn't disappear when a title disappears. And that is the most meaningful title to aspire and hold.

(Clockwise from right)
Yayoi Kusama's stainless
steel pumpkin showcased
at the 2026 India Art Fair;
the Japanese artist; Infinity
Mirror Room at NMACC;
and a mirrored art
installation in Cologne,
Germany. (AFP, GETTY IMAGES
AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)



TRIBUTE [1929-2026]

THE WOMAN BEHIND THE DOTS

Yayoi Kusama, whose dotted pumpkin was a showstopper at the 2026 India Art Fair, spent seven decades turning a private visual language into a world others could step into

Akanksha Kamath

I have this memory of walking into a Yayoi Kusama Infinity Mirror Room in Mumbai's NMACC back in 2024, when it had just opened. You purchased a nominal ticket, queued up, and had about 20 minutes of viewing (immersing) time, surrounded by glowing lights, mirrors, no beginning and no end. You kind of felt like you were floating between room, floor, mirror, and light. Then you came back out of the black box, into reality, after being consumed by what felt like the cosmos. "Our earth is only one polka dot among a million stars. Polka dots are a way to infinity," the late Japanese artist once said.

A polka dot, an almost cheerful, innocuous thing – hardly the obvious starting point for ideas about infinity, disappearance or the universe – became a preoccupation of Kusama's. She spent a lifetime making the dot carry far more than decoration. It spread across her paintings, climbed over giant pumpkins in parks, covered bodies and rooms, and multiplied endlessly in

mirrored spaces. In her world, the simplest of shapes could open out into something much larger, a way of thinking about where the self ends and everything else begins.

The dot, of course, has its own long art history, from the optical illusion of Pointillism to S.H. Raza's meditative Bindu, Damien Hirst's regimented spots and John Baldessari's bright circles obscuring faces. Closer home, Bharti Kher has made the *bindi* a recurring motif.

Private made universal

Over a career spanning more than seven decades, Kusama developed a distinct artistic language rooted in these concepts. "She explored them consistently across different mediums and decades," says Doryun Chong, artistic director and chief curator of M+ in Hong Kong. The museum's exhibition, *Yayoi Kusama: From 1945 to Now*, co-curated by Chong four years ago, was the largest retrospective of the artist in Asia outside Japan, and explored the more Eastern philosophical undertones of her works. Particularly of the Buddhist concept that speaks to transcending the self, and



embracing a more open and inclusive relationship with others and the world around us.

Her predilection for some of these motifs in her works stemmed from her own upbringing and interior world. Born in Matsumoto, Japan, in 1929, she grew up near her family's plant nursery and spoke often of childhood hallucinations in which flowers, patterns and dots seemed to spill beyond their edges.

Then there were the more tumultuous inner conversations, mired by a complicated home life. She

later wrote and spoke about her father's infidelities, her mother's volatility, and an early discomfort around sex that would eventually find its way into her work (furniture covered in soft, stuffed phallic forms). Crippled by anxiety and depression, the urge to create circles on everything from soft sculptures (she learnt sewing making military parachutes during war time in Japan), to sketches of her mother, and later, drawn on naked bodies, animals, and of course nets and pumpkins, was the artist's way of overcoming her anxious mind.



favourite artists). She fashioned herself into an image of red wig and polka dots. At the 1966 Venice Biennale, despite not being officially invited to exhibit, she installed *Narcissus Garden* – 1,500 mirrored spheres on the grass – and, dressed in a gold kimono, sold them under the sign 'Your Narcissism for Sale'. It was self-promotion and a critique of the art market, neatly tied into one. By 2019, Kusama was being described as the world's top-selling living female artist.

Before 'viral' was a word

Her work has long occupied that unusual space between serious contemporary art and mass cultural phenomenon. "It's a tension I find genuinely interesting rather than uncomfortable," says Fatema Oomerbhoy, art advisor and cultural strategist, who was part of the NMACC team involved in bringing Kusama's work to Mumbai. "The work has always possessed a fantastical, almost hallucinatory quality – one reason it can be so compelling on a phone screen."

It is a sentiment Jaya Asokan, director of India Art Fair, recognises too. Ultimately, Kusama has to be experienced. At the 2026 art fair, the artist's work, brought to the halls via international gallery partner David Zwirner, drew serious collectors, students and families. The monumental polka-dotted pumpkin, spotted from across the hall, had everyone gravitating towards it, almost instinctively. "There is an accessibility to her work that I think is very powerful," says Asokan. "I don't think we should underestimate the importance of that immediate visual connection."

And this is true. As Chong notes, Kusama's art has the ability to bend the traditional notions of art, viewer and space. Where does the artwork begin and where does the viewer end is something she deliberately flipped the script on. In London's Regent's Park, I've witnessed the giant yellow pumpkin – as you walk closer, you are part of the pumpkin, you are a polka dot. Depending on where you view it from, it's a pumpkin on a park's pumpkin patch, or it is meeting the blue sky overhead.

The writer is an independent journalist based in London, writing on fashion, luxury and lifestyle.



I think we underestimate how much scope sits in the simplicity of a circle, and how it can become a signifier based on what context it is placed in. For her [Kusama], the polka as form was like a challenge to see the possibilities of what can be done with it, and how a whole world can be created from it. For us, it began as a graphic decision and turned into a value

GURSI SINGH
Co-founder of contemporary fashion label Lovebirds, which also works with polka dots

But by doing so, Kusama showed her unusual gift for taking something intimate – fear, obsession – and giving it a shape other people could enter. "I think the more personal an artist is, the more universal the work can become," says designer Vikram Goyal, an

early admirer of Kusama's artworks. "When an artist creates from a place of honesty rather than trying to appeal to everyone, the work often finds a much wider audience." And therein lies Kusama's ability to proliferate mass culture as much as rooms occupied by high art.

The artist as image

It is also perhaps why her ideas were unable to remain contained, and needed to travel across mediums. Kusama moved restlessly between painting, sculpture, installation, performance, film, literature and fashion. Who can forget her collaboration with luxury fashion house Louis Vuitton in 2012, and then again in 2023. Her dots scattered across Neverfulls and Speedy bags, and the design and doors of entire flagship stores.

What I find most fascinating is how unapologetically she pursued fame. In an age that treats self-fashioning as second nature, that instinct was perhaps remarkably contemporary – and may be part of why Gen Z recognises something of its own culture in her (she was one of Instagram's

Tanushree Ghosh

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Three years ago, Anuparna Roy, 28, fled the trappings of an impending marriage, and left Narayanpur, her village in West Bengal's Purulia, to go study and work in call centres in Mumbai. The city now serves as the cinematic canvas for the self-taught director-screenwriter's personal stories of migration and loss.

If her 2025 debut feature, *Songs of the Forgotten Trees* (which travelled to the Venice International Film Festival), follows a migrant aspiring actress and part-time sex worker sharing a rented Mumbai apartment and forming an intimate bond, this year's *Lovers in the Blue Night* traces the entangled lives of four migrants on the city's margins: a closeted gay husband, his lonely wife, a thief and a pimp.

As a more self-assured Roy returns to the world's oldest film festival in a consecutive year, she remains the first Indian to win the Best Director award in the Orizzonti segment. She'll be a jury member at Busan International Film Festival in October.

Personal is political

In her sophomore, Roy builds on the story of Amina, who was a bonded labourer at her Narayanpur home, and whose husband Karim was a closeted gay man, and gives them an imaginary escape to Mumbai.

STEPHANIE CORNFIELD



She calls it her "responsibility" to platform marginalised stories in films.

"I'm a woman from a third world country. I can't keep cinema and politics separate. For me, losing my friend was political. Leaving my house and becoming a migrant was political. My character Karim killing rats is as political as kissing a guy," says Roy. If films like *Roma*, *The Color of Pomegranates*, *The Zone of Interest*, *Moonlight*, *Manta Ray*, and *Hot Milk* can "talk about the sociopolitical situation of their countries, why can't we?" she says. After all, party politics has "done nothing for Bengal's women".

Lens on migration

A young Roy used to be mesmerised by the river

imagery her grandmother conjured up in tales. Only to realise years later that like herself, her grandmother too was never allowed to cross her village's border to go see a river or nature's beauty. For Roy, these stories became her ammunition to flee, and the

river, a recurring motif in her films. "The conflicts my father and I share are good. If that gets resolved, I won't be able to make films," she says.

Though she wasn't allowed to step out as a child, the outside world came to her through Ritwik Ghatak's and



(Clockwise from far left) Anuparna Roy in Venice; producers Vikas Kumar and Sharib Khan; and a still from *Lovers in the Blue Night*. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)



VENICE INTERNATIONAL FILM FESTIVAL

Anuparna Roy: turning escape into art

The director, who's back in Venice after last year's win, is rewriting who gets to be seen, and how, in Indian cinema

Satyajit Ray's films on television. Roy is amused by how her Wikipedia entry "claims" that Ghatak gave her her name; the filmmaker died before Roy was born. The themes of migration and loss, however, connect their cinema. Even as her family

still clings to the idea of an undivided Bengal, she says, "Migration is very much political to me. And interstate migrations are not hyped or discussed." In *Lovers...*, the theme is also underscored through linguistic diversity: Gujarati Hindi, Jhalgaon Marathi and the disappearing Sylheti Bengali.

Filming queer complexity

Roy's films have always had male producers. "I didn't get approached by female producers, which is sad," she says, adding, "I don't like to chase producers. If I don't get one, I'm going to work hard and make my own film."

Producer Vikas Kumar, of Khan & Kumar Media, calls Roy *jhujharu*, loosely translated as soldier-like.

Producer Romil Modi (casting director on *All We Imagine as Light*, *Laapataa Ladies*) recalls Roy's message to him in 2023, to pitch *Songs of the Forgotten Trees* to Kiran Rao: "I'm not an actor. Please talk to me."

It's the same team this time, along with co-producer Neeraj Churi [Sundance-winning *Sabar Bonda*], plus a few more producers. Churi is bringing his experience of shepherding queer films through the international festival and distribution spaces to *Lovers...* "What's particularly beautiful about the film is the world in which its queer characters exist. These are working-class characters who may not necessarily have the vocabulary, agency or privilege to 'come out' in the way we have become accustomed to seeing queer lives represented in cinema," he says.

Only three more films?

Kumar and Sharib Khan (of Khan & Kumar Media) chose not to watch the final cut; they watched the film on Friday with the audience in Venice. "Once we sign on a project, we don't meddle with the creative team," says Khan. The duo will likely back Roy's next.

Meanwhile, Roy says she has just two or three more films in her – including a prequel to *Songs of the Forgotten Trees* and a period film about the 1932 Poona Pact set in Bengal. "Then, I'll sign off, unless something personal and big happens. If I were to make a lot of films, then I'm going to make nonsense," she concludes with a laugh.